A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

Out and About: Ploughing, Planting and Harvesting

Class 7 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 7 of 14

Topic: Out and About — Choresh (Ploughing), Zore'a (Planting) and Kotser (Harvesting)

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 18 December 2018 (after Chanukah)

Schedule note: Last shiur of Part 1; a winter break followed, resuming 15 January.

Recap

We have covered the kitchen melachot — cooking, selecting, threshing, grinding and kneading. Tonight we move outdoors, to three melachot normally done outside the house. (*Me'amer*, gathering, was not reached.)

Part A — Choresh (Ploughing)

Derivatives of ploughing

We rarely plough a field, but many **derivatives** (*toldot*) are equally forbidden by the Torah. Ploughing in the Mishkan prepared the land for planting the dye-plants; so any act that **improves the soil for planting** is Choresh:

- Fertiliser, manure, compost.
- **Weeding** (among other issues).
- **Levelling the ground** (*ashvuyei gumot*) — filling in a hollow or flattening a bump outdoors.
- Making a **furrow or a hole** in the earth deep enough to plant in — even without planting.

Walking sticks, buggies, heels and football studs

A walking stick pokes holes with every step; a buggy cuts furrows in soft ground; high heels and studs make holes. Since a *pesik reisha* (inevitable result) is normally forbidden even if unintended, why are these permitted?

1. **Melacha she'einah tzrichah legufah** — the holes aren't made for planting, the Mishkan purpose, so it is only rabbinic. (Likewise squeezing a pickle just to get the juice out of it, not to use the juice.)
2. **Shinui** — no one makes holes with a buggy or a walking stick; an unusual manner is only rabbinic (like writing with one's weaker hand).
3. Arguably **destructive** (*mekalkel*) — you don't want the holes.

A *pesik reisha* involving a doubly-rabbinic act is permitted. So one **may push a buggy through a park, wear heels or studs, and use a walking stick** — provided one does **not intend** the holes (e.g. to plant in them later), which would be forbidden (rabbinically, being a shinui).

Games needing a level surface

Because levelling is Choresh, Chazal forbade games that need a level surface **on earth** — originally rolling nuts, today **marbles** — lest one fill in a dip mid-game. They even forbade it indoors when most houses had earth floors; today, with tiled floors, such games are **fine indoors**, and on concrete.

- **Golf** — forbidden on Shabbat (needs a level surface on earth).
- **Tennis** — usually on hard courts, so not this problem.
- **Football** — a casual game doesn't really need a perfectly level pitch, so this isn't the issue.

Is a ball muktseh? And football on Shabbat

The Shulchan Aruch rules a **ball is muktseh** — in those days balls (made from things like an animal's stomach) had no recognised use. Today, when balls are manufactured for play, many poskim say it is hard to call a ball muktseh — designating something for use removes muktseh (as a stone designated as a doorstop). Some remain hesitant. **Children** may certainly play with a ball.

Even so, getting changed and playing a **competitive** game is hardly in the **spirit of Shabbat**. A casual kick-about for someone who needs an outlet is acceptable; but Shabbat holds so much more to do than play football.

Sweeping

Sweeping **inside** the house, even with a broom, is permitted; sweeping an **earth** area outside is not (levelling).

Questions from the floor

- **Putting garden furniture on soft earth?** — Permitted. A "hole" is made by poking in and pulling out in one act; placing a chair and later lifting it is a different act.
- **Removing a stick or stone from the ground?** — You are taking something out, not actively making a hole.

Part B — Zore'a (Planting)

Any act that assists growth

Not only planting seeds: **anything that assists growth** is forbidden by the Torah — including **watering**.

- A **sprinkler or hose** set before Shabbat, or on a timer, may run on Shabbat.
- Don't tamper with a multi-valve sprinkler system: closing one valve sends more water to the others — at least an indirect Zore'a.

Washing hands or pouring water on grass

Washing hands (e.g. netilat yadayim at a garden lunch) over grass, or tipping yesterday's rain off a garden chair onto the lawn — even in someone else's garden with no interest in it — is a *pesik reisha* and **forbidden**. This applies to water and water-based drinks (juice, Coke); not wine or chemicals, which don't benefit growth.

Indirect is permitted: washing your hands on **concrete** from which the water later trickles onto the grass — unintended and indirect (*gerama*). The same for flushing toilets or drains that run into the garden. If you intend to water the grass, it is forbidden.

Flowers in a vase — clearing up the confusion

- Cut flowers are **detached**, so water cannot make them grow — there is **no Torah prohibition**.
- Flowers **not yet fully opened** (e.g. half-opened roses): a **rabbinic** prohibition on putting them in water — it looks like planting. This applies even if the vase was filled before Shabbat, and even to put back a flower that fell out.
- **Fully opened** flowers: Sephardim may **fill a vase from the tap and put them in** on Shabbat.
- Flowers are **not muktseh** — vases and flowers may be moved, and flowers taken out.
- A **lulav** (or anything muktseh) may not have water added on Shabbat.

Flower pots: watering a pot that stands on earth with drainage holes is a **Torah** prohibition; indoors, a rabbinic one — do not water plant pots on Shabbat. Moving them may be permitted in some circumstances — ask.

Questions from the floor

- **Plant food that comes with a bouquet?** — Fine if the flowers are fully open; into a plant pot it would be forbidden by the Torah.
- **Removing dead flowers from the vase?** — Large, clearly distinct flowers are not a "mixture", so it is not Borer.
- **Flowers that open in daylight?** — Moving them to a sunny windowsill so that they open is a problem (because of the light).

Part C — Kotser (Harvesting)

Definition

Kotser = detaching something from its source of growth. Once detached, cutting it further is not Kotser — e.g. breaking a cut myrtle (hadas) leaf to release its scent, or snapping the stems of a bouquet by hand (scissors are muktseh anyway).

- **Flower pots:** bringing a perforated pot standing on soil indoors detaches it from its source of nutrients — a Torah prohibition; taking an indoor pot outside onto earth is planting.
- **Cress** sold growing in its punnet — cutting it on Shabbat is **real harvesting**, very possibly a Torah prohibition. Cut it before Shabbat and keep it in the fridge.
- Weeds or plants growing in a non-earth spot where they took root — still their place of growth; detaching them is forbidden.

- **Walking through grass** is fine; **running through long grass** should be avoided (it may inevitably uproot).

Touching and smelling plants

Attached plant	Touch?	Smell?
Soft stem, inedible (e.g. grass)	Yes	Yes
Hard stem (e.g. lavender, rosemary, cinnamon tree)	No — one may snap it	Yes, without touching
Edible, even soft (e.g. strawberry plant)	No — one may pick it	No — enjoying the smell may tempt you to pick and eat it

When smelling fragrant plants without holding them, most hold one should still say the bracha on the scent.

Using trees

Chazal were very strict about trees. One may not **climb** a tree on Shabbat — remarkably, one who climbed it deliberately and then repented must stay up until Shabbat ends (one who climbed by mistake may come down). Using a tree also includes:

- **Leaning** on it to the extent that you would fall if it were removed (merely touching it is fine).
- Prodding a ball out of a tree or bush.
- Hanging a coat on a branch — or even on a **peg directly fixed to the tree**.

Something **twice removed** is permitted:

- A **hammock** tied directly to the tree — forbidden; hung from **pegs or hooks** fixed to the tree — permitted.
- A ladder leaning directly on a tree — forbidden; on a peg attached to the tree — permitted (assuming the ladder is designated for a permitted use, else it is muktseh).

Summary

- **Choresh:** anything that improves soil for planting — fertilising, weeding, levelling, making holes. Walking sticks, buggies, heels and studs are permitted (no intent). No marbles or golf on earth; indoor tiled floors are fine. Balls are arguably not muktseh today; competitive football isn't in the spirit of Shabbat.
- **Zore'a:** anything that assists growth. Don't pour water or wash hands onto grass; indirectly via concrete is fine. Fully opened cut flowers may be put in water; unopened ones may not. Don't water plant pots.
- **Kotser:** detaching from the source of growth — beware plant pots and cress. Don't touch hard-stemmed or edible plants; smell inedible ones freely. Don't climb or lean on trees; a hammock only via pegs.

Coming Up

Part 2 of the course resumes on 15 January: Cutting, Cleaning and Colouring — haircuts and nails, cleaning and washing clothes, make-up on Shabbat. Later: Muktseh, healing on Shabbat, and asking a non-Jew. Updates on the Tiferet Eyal website.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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